



STRASBOURG FRANCE

Choucroute Garnie in Strasbourg

Strasbourg's outstanding historic architecture is now protected as a UNESCO World Heritage site; its medieval churches, grand public buildings, and tangle of narrow streets offer a unique insight into a bygone age. Long contested by both Germany and France, its shifting borders have also given it a distinctive cuisine, exemplified by a deliciously heaped platter of *choucroute garnie*.



The capital of Alsace, Strasbourg lies on the French/German border, and has habitually scuttled back and forth between France and Germany. In fact, from 1870 to 1945, it was alternately French and German no fewer than four times. Its checkered nationality is evident everywhere, from the medieval neighborhood of La Petite France to the grand Neo-Gothic German Quarter, both of which carry street signs written in French and the Germanic Alsatian dialect.

La Petite France is impossibly charming, with a web of waterways, half-timbered houses, and wooden bridges, but its hospital and noisy canal-boat workshops led the Germans to skirt the area when they annexed the city in 1870. They struck out instead past the old town, throwing up grandiose public buildings, private homes, and graceful gardens, spawning the German or Imperial Quarter. The buildings still sparkle today, and the German influence on local culinary habits remains as palpable. It's sometimes striking, in fact, just how "un-French" an Alsatian menu can seem. Thanks to Jewish immigration in the 1100s, foie gras is a firm

favorite, but German influence on local culinary habits is everywhere in evidence – sauerkraut (*choucroute*), wursts, pretzels, braised meats, gingerbread, and *kougelhopf* still loom large on an Alsatian plate.

Choucroute garnie is the Alsatian dish *par excellence*: salt-pickled cabbage braised with salted and smoked pork, and seasoned with juniper berries. The dish seems encoded in Alsatian genes, and everyone has a favorite way of making sure the *choucroute* is silky, the sausages perfectly simmered, and the pork addictive. Most recipes also include bay leaves, garlic, onions, potatoes, white Alsatian Riesling wine, and a dollop of duck or goose fat to get it started. Above all, the flavor should be delicate, not tart, so the pickled cabbage is rinsed twice before it is added to the pot. Some like to go whole hog and add a titanic ham hock, smoked pork chops, or even liver quenelles (dumplings). When it is brought to the table, a glistening hillock of *choucroute* crested with slices of smoked and salted pork, fat sausages, and steamed potatoes should provoke a gasp of delight.

A Day in Strasbourg

With its picture-postcard houses and lapping canals, Strasbourg is full of charm. A good way to get your bearings in this city is to take a canal cruise.

MORNING Visit **Notre Dame Cathedral** with its pink-hued sandstone facade and soaring spire (at 465 ft/142 m, it was the tallest monument in the world from 1647 to 1874). Its elaborate astronomical clock parades the 12 apostles at 12:30 PM. Sidle into a *winstub* (wine room) such as the one in the marvelously medieval **Maison Kammerzell** for a glass of Sylvaner wine.

AFTERNOON Spend the afternoon at the **Musée d'Art Moderne et Contemporain (MAMCO)** appreciating the works of Kandinsky, Arp, and the German Symbolists, and admiring the museum's impressive collection of *belle époque* posters. Take tea (and cake) in the light-filled **Art Café**.

EVENING Wander the cobbled, illuminated streets of **La Petite France**, with their geranium-festooned Hansel-and-Gretel-like houses. Follow the canals to the **Ponts Couverts** and survey old Strasbourg from the **Barrage de Vauban**, a dam designed to protect the city. If you have time, walk through the grandiose **German Quarter** and ponder the historical to-ing and fro-ing of this fine city.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Aéroport Strasbourg International is 6 miles (10 km) from the city; there's a **shuttle train**. Strasbourg has **high-speed train** connections across France and Europe, and a good network of **trams** and **buses** around the city.

WHERE TO STAY

Hotel 21 Siècle (inexpensive) is a minimalist, modern hotel that also offers apartments with kitchenette. www.hotel-cyber-21.com

The **Cour du Corbeau** (moderate) is housed in a 16th-century building. www.cour-corbeau.com

The Régent Petite France (expensive) is a contemporary riverside hotel in a former ice factory. www.regent-petite-france.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

17 place de la Cathédrale; www.otstrasbourg.fr

